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WAM

MOHAMMED ATTENDS 1 BILLION FOLLOWERS SUMMIT

His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, attended the fourth edition of the 1 Billion Followers Summit. The Summit drew over 30,000 attendees and 15,000 content creators and influencers and hosted over 500 speakers, with a combined audience of 3.5 billion followers, and over 150 CEOs and global experts, in more than 580 sessions and discussions. **SEE ALSO P3,15,16**

Dubai road upgrade to smoothen traffic flow

Traffic capacity on Hessa Street to double with new opening

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

Dubai's Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) yesterday opened Phase I of Hessa Street Development Project which has a total cost of approximately Dh690 million and extends from Al Khail Road to Sheikh Zayed Road over a length of 4.5km. The works included the widening of Hessa Street, along

with bridges at intersections with Al Asayel Street, First Al Khail Street, and Sheikh Zayed Road, expanding capacity to four lanes in each direction.

90% project completion

This opening enhances traffic flow for vehicles travelling from Al Khail Road towards Hessa Street and onwards to Sheikh Zayed Road. Project completion has reached 90 per cent, with the remaining road works, bridges, intersection improvements, and cycling tracks scheduled for completion in the second quarter of this year.

Mattar Al Tayer, Director General, Chairman of the

Board of Executive Directors of RTA, said: "The population of the areas served by the project is expected to exceed 640,000 residents by 2030. The project will double traffic capacity on Hessa Street, increasing capacity from 8,000 vehicles per hour in both directions to 16,000 vehicles per hour.

"The project includes developing dedicated cycling and e-scooter tracks extending 13.5km, 4.5 metres wide. The track links Al Sufouh and Dubai Hills via Hessa Street and serves several residential neighbourhoods, including Al Barsha and Barsha Heights."

SEE ALSO P2

Iran threatens US, Israel as protests rage

TRUMP WEIGHS OPTIONS AS RIGHTS GROUPS CITE MOUNTING DEATH TOLL

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Iran warned that any US military strike ordered by President Donald Trump would trigger retaliation against Israel and American forces in the Middle East, as Israel placed its military on high alert amid fears of a US intervention linked to the country's most serious anti-regime protests in years.

The warning came from Iran's parliament speaker, Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf, who said Israel and US military installations and shipping in the region would be considered "legitimate targets" if Washington attacks the Islamic Republic, marking a sharp escalation as nationwide unrest continues to challenge Iran's ruling theocracy.

Despite a near-total communications shutdown now stretching beyond 60 hours, large crowds again took to the streets overnight in cities including Tehran and Mashhad. Videos circulating online showed burning vehicles, clashes with security forces and grieving families inside morgues.

'Massacre is unfolding'

The US-based Centre for Human Rights in Iran warned that a "massacre is unfolding", citing eyewitness accounts and credible reports that hundreds may have been killed. Another rights

group, the Human Rights Activists News Agency, said it had confirmed at least 192 deaths while cautioning that the true toll may be higher due to the blackout. On Saturday, Trump wrote on social media that "Iran is looking at FREEDOM, perhaps like never before. The USA stands ready to help!!!"

The *New York Times* and the *Wall Street Journal* reported, citing US officials, that Trump has been presented with military options for a potential strike on Iran, though no final decision has been taken. The US State Department issued a blunt warning: "Do not play games with President Trump. When he says he'll do something, he means it."

President Masoud Pezeshkian, in his first remarks since the unrest intensified, said peaceful protest was a right but warned that "rioters" must not be allowed to disrupt society, echoing official claims that the unrest is being fuelled by the US and Israel.

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